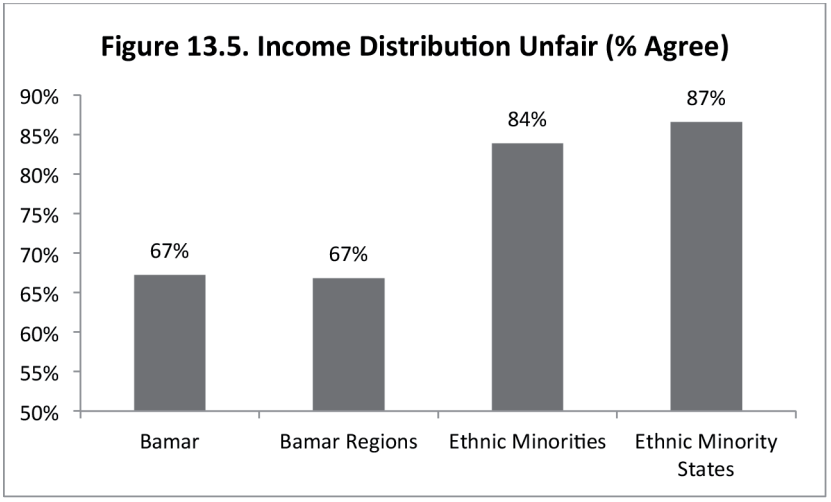


While the differences among the Bamar majority and ethnic minorities are present, there is considerable common ground on the political solutions to these different views and experiences, notably with regard to decentralization of political power. The ABS asked questions on federalism and autonomy with promising results.

There is consensus among citizens from different communities about strengthening a federal system. Respondents were asked to agree or disagree with the following statement: "We should strengthen a federal system in Myanmar and give more power to state/regional governments." A majority of all the communities concur that a federal system should be strengthened. This support for decentralization exists despite Myanmar not yet having a federal system in place. The percentages are slightly higher among ethnic minorities (seventy-nine per cent compared to seventy per cent), but the shared positive view of decentralizing authority bodes well for measures that can ameliorate ethnic conflict. The numbers increase when Myanmar citizens are asked about the selection of chief ministers who govern states and regions, as over eighty per cent of all communities support decentralizing the choice of leadership of chief ministers to their regional parliaments.

The common ground over decentralization extends to increasing autonomy as well, with over two-thirds supporting increased autonomy, as shown in Figure 13.6. Respondents were asked to agree or disagree with the following statement: "In Myanmar, ethnic minorities should